

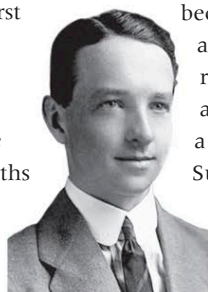
A Sopwith Snipe on the front line at the end of World War I



Great Manufacturers Sopwith

Between 1912 and 1920, the Sopwith Aviation Company designed and manufactured more than 40 different types of aircraft. More than 16,000 Sopwith aircraft were built during the first full decade of powered flight, and its products contributed significantly to the progress of civil and military aircraft design.

BORN IN KENSINGTON, West London, in 1888, Thomas Octave Murdoch Sopwith was 15 years old when the Wright brothers made the first manned powered flight in 1903. Self-taught, Sopwith flew his Howard Wright Monoplane for the first time in October 1910. A few months later he won a £4,000 prize for flying the greatest distance non-stop into Europe from England. He used that money to buy more aircraft, and in March 1912 set up the Sopwith School of Flying at Brooklands, Surrey. He formed the Sopwith Aviation Company three months later.



Thomas Sopwith
(1888-1989)

The company's first aircraft, the Sopwith Three-seater Tractor Biplane or "Hybrid" was made from an assortment of parts and powered by a 70hp Gnome engine. It attracted

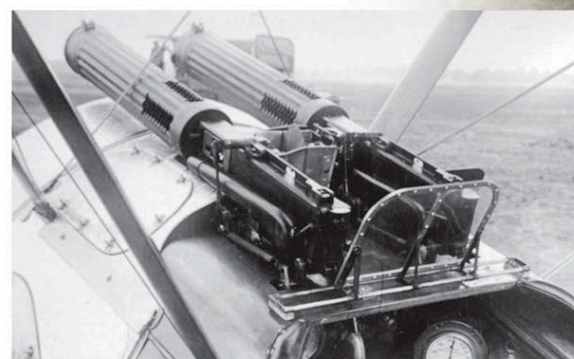
the interest of the Royal Naval Air Service (RNAS), who bought it. As a result, the Sopwith Aviation Company became a nominated military aircraft contractor. The cash received from the contract allowed Sopwith to acquire a disused skating rink in Surrey, and convert it into an aircraft production factory.

In 1913, a Sopwith three-seater, flown by chief pilot Harry Hawker, set two new altitude records. It was shown at the 1913 Olympia Aero Show alongside the Bat Boat I—the first British flying boat and the world's first successful amphibian. Impressed with Sopwith's ingenuity, the RNAS paid £1,500 for the modified Bat Boat 1A.

The company developed a number of projects such as the Admiralty Type C seaplane, intended as an airborne

Twin Vickers guns

Vickers machine guns mounted in front of the cockpit were used for the first time in the Sopwith Camel. The shape of the hump over the guns led to the name Camel being given to the plane.



torpedo launcher, but Sopwith's first truly successful aircraft was the Tabloid scout biplane. Principally designed by Harry Hawker, the Tabloid, with its high speed, good rate of climb, and handling qualities, performed better than other military monoplane designs. A float-equipped version won the Schneider Trophy, a speed competition held for seaplanes, at Monaco in April 1914. The Schneider seaplane was put into production for the RNAS. It was later modified and became the Sopwith Baby—a scout and bomber widely used from 1915.

Designed by Sopwith's chief engineer Herbert Smith, the 1916 1½ Strutter, so named because of its unusual wing strut arrangement, featured an advanced gun design that allowed pilots to fire forward through the propeller arc for the first time. More than 1,500 1½ Strutters were assembled in England and many more were pieced together in France for the

French Army. Fast and well armed, the two-seat 1½ Strutter served first as a front-line fighter, then as a bomber until late 1917.

The smaller single-seat Sopwith Pup was also widely used by the Royal Flying Corps (RFC) and RNAS from late 1916 to fall of 1917. Its successor, the Triplane, used much of the Pup's design but had new triple, narrow-chord wings. It initially excelled in air-to-air combat before a number of structural issues emerged.

Next off the production line was the F1 Camel, the first British fighter with twin Vickers machine guns. The Camel was extremely agile and the most effective Allied fighter during World War I. Camels shot down 1,294 enemy aircraft—more than any other Allied fighter—from their introduction in mid-1917. Further success came with the Sopwith Snipe. Just over 2,000 Snipes were built, and they were the standard front-line fighter for the Royal Air Force until 1926.

After World War I, Sopwith's designers began producing civilian versions of military designs and diversified into producing motorcycles. However, by the summer of 1920,



Aviation pioneer

Harry Hawker, seen here in 1914, was a test pilot and aircraft designer at Sopwith. He was fundamental to the success of the company and later founded Hawker Aircraft.